

Image 1.4: Maharaja Gulab Singh, the first ruler of the Dogra Dynasty (1846–57)
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Ranbir Singh: Successor to Gulab Singh

In February 1856, because of his failing health, Maharaja Gulab Singh abdicated his throne in favour of his third and youngest son Ranbir Singh, with the permission of the British. The new Maharaja was able to quell the rebellion in Gilgit and expand the empire to include the principalities of Puniyal, Yasin, Hunza and Nagar. Even though Maharaja Ranbir Singh was an independent and expansionist ruler, he maintained close ties with the British as had his father. He played a crucial role in suppressing the nationalist forces in the First War of Independence in 1857 and, for this, he earned the gratitude of the British. They awarded him the title of ‘Grand Commander of the Star of India’.

Ranbir Singh not only built upon the kingdom that he had inherited from his father, but he also expanded his empire to share common borders